

THE *SLAVES OF FASHION* EXHIBITION, BY THE SINGH TWINS (RIGHT), IS ON DISPLAY AT THE NORWICH CASTLE MUSEUM AND EAST GALLERY OF THE NORWICH UNIVERSITY OF THE ARTS TILL JAN. 22, 2023



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For an Indian viewer, the image of Mumtaz Mahal—in whose memory the Mughal emperor Shah Jahan had the magnificent mausoleum Taj Mahal built—is a familiar one. We've seen it in everything from school texts to decorative objects and theatre. So, the sight of the monarch in a pair of jeans in a medieval castle some 160 kilometres from London triggers a strange stirring. It's like bumping into an old friend after decades—you recognise her, yet she seems entirely different. The mixed media artwork 'Indigo: The Colour of India'—a combination of traditional hand painting, digital elements and scanned historical archival material—is part of The Singh Twins' *Slaves of Fashion* exhibition, on display at Norwich Castle Museum and East Gallery at Norwich University of the Arts till January 22, 2023.

Founded by William the Conqueror in the 11th century, the castle in Norwich, UK, is listed as a building of exceptional interest (Grade 1), and that it has, at different times, served as both a prison and a sanctuary makes it the perfect venue for an exhibition that presents the dual narratives around India's textile history. "The exhibition, which took four years to create, explores narratives of the Empire, colonialism, conflict and slavery through the lens of India's historical textile trade, and the relevance of these themes to modern-day legacies and debates around environment, ethical consumerism, racism and the politics of trade—all of which are equally important at this time," say the artists.

Based in Merseyside in North West England, The Singh Twins are known to make hard-hitting political statements through their works—which are often inspired by India's miniature painting tradition. The late Queen Elizabeth even conferred an MBE (The Most Excellent Order of the British Empire) upon them in recognition of their 'Services to the Indian miniature tradition of painting within Contemporary Art' in 2011. Their long list of accolades includes the UK Asian Achievers Awards for Media, Arts and Culture and two honorary doctorates.

One work in the ongoing exhibition, titled 'Get Your Knee off Our Necks', was created in response to the murder of George Floyd by a police officer in Minnesota, US, in May 2020. "As an event that shocked the world, demonstrating how racial hatred is still ingrained in society, this piece shows how important it is to promote a better and more balanced understanding of our shared colonial past," say the sisters, who feel the artwork "promotes one of the core aims of the exhibition".

The designs have been mounted on lightboxes, which allow viewers to fully take in the intricate details, and although the symbolism may be missed, viewers can also simply enjoy each piece for its aesthetic charm. For those who want to know more, there are displays that reveal how various elements were incorporated into the works. Nothing in the designs is purely ornamental; every seed, shell and flower holds a part of the story, whether it's about the skill of craftsmen, the human cost of the luxury goods India once produced or the ongoing competition in the EU for trade pacts with India.

In 'Cotton: Threads of Change', which shows prominent UK suffragette